

Krakatoa

Sunda Strait, Indonesia

Eruption August 1883

Features Explosion, pyroclastic flows, tsunamis

Estimated death toll 36,417

In 1883, Krakatoa exploded, causing pyroclastic flows and tsunamis that killed thousands of people. The explosion may have been the loudest ever heard.



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Ongoing eruptions have caused a new volcano to rise from the crater of the old. It is called Anak Krakatoa, which means "Child of Krakatoa" in Indonesian.

Mount Pinatubo

Luzon, Philippines

Eruption June 1991

Features Ash cloud, pyroclastic flows, mudslides

Estimated death toll 800

The 1991 eruption of Mount Pinatubo blew the top off the volcano and ejected about 2.4 cubic miles (10 cubic km) of ash and rock into the air. This caused a colossal ash cloud and deadly pyroclastic flows. Fine ash smothered the landscape, and created a layer of sulfuric acid haze all around the world.

Tambora

Sumbawa, Indonesia

Eruption April 1815

Features Explosion, tsunamis, global ash cloud

Estimated death toll 60,000

This was the biggest volcanic eruption in recorded history—the explosion was heard from 1,243 miles (2,000 km) away. Gas and ash spread worldwide, dimming the Sun for so long that 1816 became known as “the year without a summer.” Crops stopped growing, causing the worst famine of the century.

Mount Pelée

Martinique, West Indies

Eruption May 1902

Features Ash cloud, pyroclastic flows

Estimated death toll 29,500

The city of Saint-Pierre below Mount Pelée was crowded with people when the volcano exploded and a vast cloud of ash poured out. The cloud became a pyroclastic flow that surged toward Saint-Pierre at more than 400 mph (650 km/h), reaching the city in under a minute and completely destroying it. Virtually everyone was killed.

Vesuvius

Naples, Italy



Eruption August 79 CE

Features Ash cloud, pyroclastic flows

Estimated death toll 2,100

The most famous eruption of all time occurred in the year 79 CE, during the Roman Empire. Vesuvius had been dormant for centuries, but then erupted

with catastrophic violence. Pyroclastic flows buried the Roman towns of Pompeii and Herculaneum, killing anyone who could not escape.

Santorini

Greek Aegean Islands

Eruption c. 1600 BCE

Features Explosion, ash cloud, tsunami

Estimated death toll Unknown

Many thousands of years ago, this island volcano exploded, creating a huge water-filled crater. A new volcano appeared, and 3,600 years ago it also exploded, causing a gigantic tsunami. Now, the volcano (in the center of the sea-filled crater) is growing again.

